

KF34 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

In this lesson we will continue with the **Lectio Divina** meditation.

When you practice the Lectio Divina in your own meditation time, try reading a longer passage—perhaps a paragraph or a story from the Gospels. Engage with the passage by following the same steps.

Take the meditation posture by sitting upright. Straighten your neck as you lower your chin a little. Allow your shoulders to relax and fall back. *(Pause)* Scan your body for tension and release it on the exhale. You might use the word *CALM* to center yourself. Breathe and prepare for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

1. Read the passage

I will read a short text from the Bible and then pause. You might wish to allow the words to rise and fall in your mind with your breath. Our text is from the first chapter of James, verse 4.

*Give endurance a chance to accomplish its oriented outcome.
(Repeat) (Pause for 10 seconds)*

2. Receive as you listen

Relax while I read the sentence three times, pausing between readings. Take the attitude of a listener and attend to your experience with the Scripture. In the stillness between the readings, allow a feeling, thought, or image to come to mind that may be related to the words. If nothing comes, notice the absence or just enjoy the stillness. Observe with compassion any other feelings or thoughts that may intrude, and then return to our text. Let’s begin.

*Give endurance a chance to accomplish its oriented outcome.
(Read 3 times, pausing for 30 seconds after each reading)*

3. Respond

Now, whatever your experience might be, respond to God with affirmation and gratitude. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

4. Rest in awareness

Rest in stillness for one minute as you contemplate whatever has happened during this time. You might allow the Scripture to gently recede and then focus your mind on your breath. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Pause and re-engage with your environment. You may wish to take this next minute to rest or to record your experience, perhaps in your KF journal or on your **Meeting Preparation Guide**. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

And pause.

Our hymn for KF Confession 8 is *And Can It Be?* by Charles Wesley.

He left His Father's throne above,
So free, so infinite His grace!
Emptied Himself of all but love,
And bled for Adam's helpless race.
'Tis mercy all, immense and free,
For, O my God, it found out me.
'Tis mercy all, immense and free,
For, O my God, it found out me!¹

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

In KF Confession 8 we commit to partnering with God in the rescue of our True Self:

We co-labor with the Creator to seek and to save that which was lost.

This month we are learning about the CORE muscles of our soul. CORE—C-O-R-E—stands for Courage, Orientation, Reality, Endurance. Last week we looked how life experiments offer effective training opportunities to grow our courage. When we walk through suffering or success mindfully, we develop the muscle of our courage, which increases our confidence to explore other challenges— challenges that we know will bring more suffering and, also, more success. Challenges stretch our courage, our ability to remain oriented, our engagement with reality, and our endurance. When my personal trainer says that he would like to “stretch me out”, I know that I will suffer. This new challenge of suffering will require courage on my part. It's difficult for me to exercise courage, but I know that if I don't stretch beyond my perceived limitations, I won't get strong, and I need to be strong to fight easy. Courage grows as we stretch into discomfort and use our tools to tackle the next obstacle and reach toward new territory.

When you build a muscle at the gym, you work against some kind of resistance, and when you build the muscle of courage, the resistance you work against is fear. I discovered the quality of my courage when, early in our marriage, my husband was given military orders to move to Germany. My fear reaction told me that my faith in God did not include taking my babies to live in foreign countries. I remember crying and telling my husband that I was afraid to go. He kindly reminded me that God lives in Germany, too. I

realized that I wasn't going to Germany as much as I was going to God. Whenever we are stretched by a new challenge, we are going to God. When we courageously choose to go forward, we experience a sensitive apprehension, which strengthens and sharpens our ability to trust Him. Healthy and realistic apprehension breaks down our resistance to change and makes us more open to listening and looking for God's guidance. Be thankful for your fear.

Courage is not the absence of fear. It is deciding that something is more important than your fear. It is choosing to act in an oriented manner when fear is goading you to return to habitual and misoriented ways of relieving anxiety. Think of it this way: every real virtue is developed in the face of fear, courage is the soil in which every virtue is planted, and endurance gives every virtue time to grow.

Use your tools and ask God to help you calm your fear. With great courage, tell Him that in this moment you are willing to lose your life and take up your challenge to act as skillfully and as wisely as you know how. Tell Him you are willing to let go of controlling the outcome. Then, with endurance, stand in reality and see what God does.

You cannot seek and save your True Self if you continue to choose misorientation. All misorientation is the work of the Idol Self. Your Idol likes to say, "I did it my way," but actually *doing it my way* only means that you reacted to the fear of death with your habitual patterns—that is, you asserted your claims, met the demands of your shoulds, and maintained your pride system. *My way* is no way at all. It is the hamster wheel that uses up your resources but goes nowhere. We have all seen people who do their own thing, offer only feeble contributions to the community, and never make substantial progress in their personal lives. These people end up becoming chaotic, demanding, or listless. By contrast, those who have trained to live lives of courageous virtue experience spontaneous love, joy, and peace and have access to all kinds of marvelous gifts.

With growing courage, we can learn to reach for orientation in more areas of our lives. Acting in oriented ways is sometimes called *obedience*. The idea of obedience might be repulsive to you, so you may feel rebellious right now. That is understandable because many of us have experienced abuse in the name of obedience. Authorities in our lives did not consider our needs or desires. They just imposed on us their compulsive need for control. On the other hand, some of us were never taught to obey, and from that neglect we learned that obedience is bad, unnecessary, or too hard—something that demands too much effort and offers no reward. When God tells us to obey, however, He is giving us a gift. He is not impoverishing us or using us. He is training us to be free. To obey God is to recognize that we are creatures who thrive when we live according to our design. God is our Designer, and He knows how we work and what works for us. Trust Him to bring into your life what will train and build your True Self for fulfillment and freedom.

Through the guidance in the Bible, God is showing you how to create a healthy, stable lifestyle that circulates enough vitality to recognize and resist your own toxic patterns and those of others. With the strength that comes from stability and growing health, you can tackle the messed-up energy that you have inherited and deal with whatever mess you have already created; you can withstand the toxic energy around you.

God uses your limitations to guide you in paths of orientation. Within the boundaries of those limitations He gives your True Self the freedom and space to develop its glory. Orientation is living in harmony with God and with the Creation. The Creation includes your body, your personality, your mission, and, also, your community. The Creation flows within the limitations of its design, and as we work within the

limitations of our design, our lives line up with the flow of life. Oriented people are ecosystems that are spiritually and energetically cleansing themselves; and by cleansing themselves, they cleanse their environment. Misoriented people become more and more toxic. Through their misoriented choices, they pollute their lives, their bodies, and their energy—and, like any polluted ecosystem, they pollute the systems around them. We have all been polluted by toxic people. Perhaps you are related to some of them. We often focus on cleaning up our physical environment, and rightly so, but cleaning up the energetic ecosystem of our families may be our most important mission in this world.

Just as there are rules in the darkroom for developing film, so there are rules in life for developing your True Self.² By choosing to obey these rules, you clean up your life, and you help clean up the energetic path of those who went before you. You also provide a cleaner environment for those who follow you. So, when you read the Bible, look for examples of do's and don'ts and try not to fear this guidance. Telling stories about how restrictive or hard that guidance is won't benefit you or anyone else. Instead, recognize the hope that this guidance brings.

Now that you know how to manage your self-hate, you can courageously face whatever reality your choices reveal about your faith, the quality of your orientation, and your commitment to your own growth and mission. You can then valiantly choose to reorient to an authentic life, seeking and saving what has been lost. All that you learn in this process will be woven into the fabric of your real glory. The Father of glory wants to glorify you in your True Self, the self that He designed, so that you might glorify Him. You will discover that the recovery of what you have lost will become part of your message to those in this sick world who have lost the same thing. Give up the Idol and its compulsive illusions about who you should be. No matter what has happened to you, your True Self is still there, waiting to be discovered, nurtured, and supported while you press on to real glory.

Our prayer might go something like this:

*Lord Jesus, support me as I make oriented choices to nurture my True Self and reveal my true glory.
(Repeat)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Heaven rejoices when we start to practice KF Confession 8:³

We co-labor with the Creator to seek and to save that which was lost.

Our Bible passages for this lesson are taken from chapter 15 of the Gospel of John and chapter 3 of First Peter. Let's start with my translation of **John 15:1–15**. Jesus is teaching about the relationship between the True Vine and its branches.

¹I and no other am the True Vine, and my Father is the vinedresser. ²All the branches attached to Me that are not bearing fruit He takes away, and all the branches that are bearing fruit He prunes back so that they can carry more fruit. ³You are already pruned

branches because of the logos I told you about. ⁴In all of your activities, remain in Me, even as I am remaining in you. Just as the branch must remain connected to the vine in order to bear fruit, so you must remain connected to Me. ⁵I, and no other, am the Vine and you are the branches. The one who remains connected to Me in the same way that I remain connected to them bears a lot of fruit, because apart from Me you are not able to produce a single thing. ⁶If a person does not remain connected to Me, that person is thrown away and dries up, and others gather together those dried branches to throw them into the fire as kindling. ⁷If you live in Me, however, and My sayings are alive in you, ask for whatever you want—it will become a new state of being for you. ⁸When you become My disciples and bear much fruit, others benefit and they honor My Father. ⁹Just as the Father is well-pleased with Me, I am well-pleased with you. Live in My love. ¹⁰If you guard My commands, you will remain in My love, just as I have guarded My Father's commands and remain in His love. ¹¹I have told you these things so that you might experience My joy and that your joy might be complete. ¹²This is My command: love each other just as I have loved you. ¹³No one has a greater love than this—to lay down one's life or conscious self on behalf of one's friends. ¹⁴You are My friends if you produce the kind of life that I command. ¹⁵I am telling you that you are no longer slaves, because a slave does not know what kind of life the master is producing. By telling you this, I am treating you like friends, because what I have heard from My Father I am making known to you.

Take a deep breath.

In this passage we see that Jesus is the source of our fruit. If we focus on the fruit, we know that we have invested pride in it; we are hoping that the fruit will serve our search for an idealized glory. If we are focused on the source of our true glory, Jesus, we know that our fruit reflects His glory and that we can peacefully trust Him to produce whatever fruit He wishes in its season.

1. Jesus is the True Vine

Jesus calls Himself the True Vine. This implies that there is a false vine, and I would call this false vine the Idol Self. Our fruit tells us from which vine we are deriving our life. The True Self is a branch connected to the True Vine, and its motivation, outcomes, and sustenance are all derived from that Vine. If we choose to be connected to Jesus, the True vine, we are supporting the True Self. Only the truth can support what is true. Even when we are connected to truth, however, we find that our True Self must be pruned. In fact, the more fruit we produce, the more we are pruned. Have you ever seen a grapevine that's been pruned for winter? At this dormant stage of its life cycle, the vine is unproductive and unattractive. From a distance the vine looks dead, and you would swear that it could never produce fruit again. You might feel that way about yourself. But if you understand the growth cycle of the vine, you will know that the vine is not dead. It is quietly enduring the winter while it secretly and mysteriously recharges and prepares to produce abundant fruit in the spring. The vine demonstrates the power of productive cycles. There is a time to bear fruit in our lives, and there is a time to be pruned and rest. When we are pruned, we may feel fear and self-hate. Where is all of that glorious fruit that we have come to expect? At these times, it is important to remember that our connection is with the True Vine and not with the fruit. When we try to connect to the fruit, we are attaching to particular outcomes, to judgments about quality and quantity, and to a desperate desire for permanence—the claim that things should go on just as they did yesterday. Nothing is permanent, and that is a great thing. You are a creature living in cycles. You do not want to be limited to producing the same amount of fruit year after year. You want to grow.

2. We glorify the Father by bearing much fruit

The Fruit of the Spirit and our oriented choices can be seen by others.⁴ When people see this fruit in us, they recognize the character of Jesus, who is the true Vine and the material expression of the Father. We honor God our Father by remaining connected to the Vine and bearing fruit in our season. There are seasons when you will produce abundant fruit, and that fruit is clear evidence of your connection to the Vine. There will also be seasons of rest when you produce little or no apparent fruit. In those seasons, it is your endurance that is the evidence of your connection to the Vine. It isn't really your business whether you are resting or producing fruit; it is the business of the True Vine. Your business is to consistently abide in the love of Jesus. We abide in His life-giving love by taking the Believe It Path, letting go of judgments, and following His guidance. In this way, we guard His commandments, and at the same time we guard ourselves. When we disregard His commandments and trust in deceptive ideas or beliefs, we harm ourselves.⁵

3. We abide in the love of Jesus through obedience

The circulating life force of the True Vine is love. If we remain in the Vine, we have access to this love, which, like breath, flows in and through us in harmony with God and the Creation. In this state of harmony, we can do astonishing things. How do we stay attached to Jesus, the True Vine? We stay attached to the True Vine by abiding in His love, and we abide in His love through obedience. Later in this passage, we see that the all-encompassing command of Jesus is to love one another. Loving acts and words support our own orientation and the orientation of others. When we are oriented, the love of God is expressed toward us and through us—and through us His love circulates into the world. Living in that place of circulating love with other branches on the True Vine is a place of abundant joy.

Let's flip over to **First Peter 3:8–12**, which we will read in my paraphrase.

⁸Here is a summary of what I've just been saying: All of you, be like loving family—harmonious, compassionate, tender-hearted, and humble in spirit. ⁹Get into a healthy cycle of blessing others and inheriting a blessing instead of perpetuating the destructive cycle of law-keepers, who return harm for harm and restore their hurt pride by punishing others. Your choice to bless others depends on your karis relationship with God; it does not depend on what others do or don't do. ¹⁰Do you remember Psalm 34? "Those who desire to live well—to love and to experience good days—reveal that intention by refusing to speak the harm on the tip of their tongues and by refusing to use polite words to cloak resentful wrath. Those who choose life take responsibility for their feelings. They choose to swerve away from harming the Creation, and they do good to themselves and to others. They seek peace and pursue it like a hunter. ¹²Why do they choose to live this way? Because the eyes of the Lord are toward the oriented and His ears attend to their prayer, but the face of the Lord is actively against those who perpetuate misorientation."

Take a deep breath.

God has invited you into a karis relationship with Him so that you can inherit His blessing. You can't inherit His blessing if you continue to live life your own way—taking cheap, habitual shortcuts to relieve your anxiety and save your Idol's pride. By consistently following Peter's short list of do's and don'ts, you maintain your orientation and invest in your stock portfolio of blessing, which in due season will produce abundant and glorious fruit. Your hard-trained endurance gives that fruit time to grow. James writes, "Allow endurance to achieve its designed outcome." This designed outcome is that you should become mature, complete, and lacking nothing. Like a fond father, the eyes of the Lord are toward the oriented,

those who are in karis relationship with Him, and His ears attend to their prayer. God earnestly hopes that we will choose to enter into the inheritance of all that He intends for us—an inheritance of influence and joy.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord of blessing, whatever it takes, bring me into my inheritance of blessing. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water, and you might prepare to take some notes. Assume your meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider an area of your life where you might invest to inherit a blessing. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider an area of your life where you might invest to inherit a blessing*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Our feelings are ours to teach us about ourselves, to guide us, and to train us. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* We can learn to recognize and honor our feelings without allowing them to master us, or anyone else. *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness. Observe whatever tension you may be feeling as you *consider where you might invest to inherit a blessing*. You might notice a compulsion to push away or excuse thoughts and feelings, or to make up a virtue story. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider this area of your life where you might invest to inherit a blessing*. *(Pause)* You might notice what an old pattern of rationalizing or an old story feels like in your body. You might feel compulsive strain, pushing, and craving or, perhaps, the fear of loss. Gently keep your attention focused on whatever you might be sensing. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to respectfully observe those uncomfortable sensations. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider this area of your life where you might invest to inherit a blessing*. Does that feel pleasant, unpleasant, or

vague and slippery? Just observe. *(Pause)* What do you believe when you consider this investment? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Are you afraid of something—of yourself, of others, or of loss? Perhaps you feel hope. Observe your experience as just information, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

God created all of us to have feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have felt like you feel when they have *considered making an investment in their future inheritance of blessing*. You can stop telling stories about this investment by asking yourself, “Are my present investment choices reflecting who I really am in Christ? How might I invest today in a future of blessing?” *(Pause)* With compassion for yourself and for others who are making this choice to invest, breathe and help your body process with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time together of healing and redirection. Hold us in this orientation toward You and toward our inheritance in Christ. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our true design and potential, with our community and the rest of Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ *And Can It Be?* by Charles Wesley (1707–1788); www.youtube.com/watch?v=sQelGbKgiw8.

² See KF6 Expanded.

³ Luke 15:7, 10, 32.

⁴ Gal. 5:22-23, Matt. 5:16.

⁵ Jer. 7:5–8.